‘was displeased at the impropriety’. Abu’l Fazl implied that the impropriety arose from the fact that Salim was already married to the niece of Zain Khan Koka. Nonetheless, by marrying his daughter, Salim was further binding to his cause the powerful milk brother of Akbar and the three men, united by the unlikely and whimsical bond of poetry, formed an enduring partnership.

If Salim had managed to outmanoeuvre his brothers and had them sent away from court, there still remained one man whose influence on his father the prince detested and whom Salim increasingly blamed for Akbar’s disappointment in him. Abu’l Fazl was by now a mansabdar of 2,000 and a man whom many were jealous of because he had won the Padshah’s trust and affection. ‘He kept constant company with Akbar, like the setting to a pearl,’ wrote a contemporary biographer about Abu’l Fazl, ‘and nothing was done without his approval.’ This made Abu’l Fazl the target of sustained rancour from other powerful courtiers but also, fatally, from Salim. It was at this time that a triumphant Salim had chanced upon Abu’l Fazl surrounded by mullahs copying the Koran and Abu’l Fazl further earned Akbar’s displeasure by forwarding copies of a commentary written by his father, which did not have the Padshah’s approval. In his biography Abu’l Fazl admitted that he had also angered the Padshah by not being attentive in his duties to Salim. ‘From not fully considering the matter he [Salim] became somewhat angry and base and envious people had their opportunity,’ complained Abu’l Fazl. ‘The anger of that hot-tempered one [Salim] blazed forth, and meetings were held for troubling his [Akbar’s] heart’. As soon as Abu’l Fazl earned the Padshah’s wrath, he was sent off in early 1599 on the first major expedition of his life, to the Deccan, to assist Murad, for the Mughal expedition to the south would become unexpectedly complicated by the uncompromising valour and foresight of a woman.

*A mansabdar of 7,000, the highest at the time.